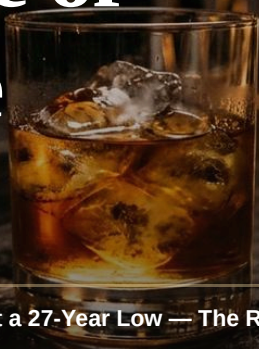


DATA SPECIAL · CHUSEOK D-22

The Age of Volume Is Over



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Beer, soju and makgeolli shrink — so what is growing?

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What U.S. data on 21–28 year-olds is telling us

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Autumn's First Signal Comes After the Rain

The late-August downpour broke the heat — this is the week to watch the three switch signals.

Editor's note — "Shipments at a 27-year low" sounds frightening. Read the numbers to the end, though, and what emerges is not fear but a map. This issue draws that map.

Three Million Kiloliters, Broken

Korea shipped 2.988 million kiloliters of liquor last year — below the 3-million line for the first time since the 1998 financial crisis (National Tax Service). Down more than 20% in a decade. But read only half this number, and you get it wrong.

Drinks That Shrink, Drinks That Grow

The decline is not across the board. Volume drinks shrink; taste drinks grow. Tax, convenience-store and social data in one chart.

SHRINKING · NTS 2025 SHIPMENTS Volume Drinks Beer 1.518m kl — down 3 years running Diluted soju 793k kl — down 3 years running Makgeolli 318k kl — down 5 years running	GROWING · RETAIL & SOCIAL DATA Taste Drinks Distilled soju sales +18.6% (CVS Jan–Jul, 2.5× regular soju) Japanese beer imports +33.5% — a 10-year high (Customs, H1) Non-alcoholic — Instagram mentions +41% in a month Whisky — steady ~2,000 weekly mentions all summer; value whisky surging
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← DRINKING A LOT · DRINKING BY CHOICE →

Total volume is shrinking structurally — fewer office dinners, health consciousness and a falling population all push the same way, and none of it reverses. Yet over the same period guests moved to "drink less, but drink properly." It is happening inside beer itself: domestic beer shipments fell three years running, while Japanese beer imports hit a 10-year high this half, up 33.5% (Customs) — half of all imported beer is now Japanese. On Instagram, the words attached to whisky are not price but flavor, aroma, taste, mood and space. Taste is moving, not volume. The age of volume selling is over — the liquor business is not.

The check is simple: does your menu's center of gravity sit in the left column, or the right?

The Generation That Drinks Less Spends More

A study flatly contradicts the cliché that young people are cutting back on going out: the Questex×Datassential consumer survey (Mar 2026, U.S.).

Self-reward 53% · Socializing 45% · Respond to promos 42%

Americans aged 21–28 go out more often than any other age group, spend the most per occasion, and order premium drinks. Price is not a barrier — going out is itself a self-reward (53%) and a social occasion (45%).

It is U.S. data, but the direction matches Korea. The growth of distilled soju, whisky and highballs seen on the previous page stands exactly on this psychology. The U.S. bar industry's 2026 keyword is likewise "selective premiumization" (Distiller Magazine) — cut the everyday drinks, open the wallet for the special one. Falling volume does not mean falling spend per guest — not in bars that design for it.

Three actions for owners. First, put a "proper glass" on the menu — a signature highball, whisky on the rocks, premium distilled soju. Second, dress that glass in reward — the glassware, the ice, the serve. Third, post the promotions 42% respond to. Compete on value, not price.

※ Source: Questex×Datassential 'On-Premise Consumer Habits Report' (Bar & Restaurant, Mar 2026) — a U.S. survey; the Korean market may differ.



RADAR · DISTRICTS

In a Shrinking Market, Where Does the Money Go?

Within 1km of Gangnam Station, eight major F&B openings in six months — Chipotle's first Asian store (imminent), a bhc flagship, BBQ's Ukuya (izakaya by night), Olipepe, Paul Bassett, Benson, Van Leeuwen, Chagee. Prime Gangnam office vacancy: 0.3%. Daily riders at Gangnam Station: 150,000. The more the market shrinks, the more capital crowds into proven districts — the density of competition is the market's answer.

SOURCE · MONEY TODAY 2026.08 / PHOTO · EDITORIAL

Three Menu Questions — Which Side Is Your Bar On?

Q1 THE PREMIUM GLASS

Whisky on the rocks, premium distilled soju, a signature highball — is there a "proper glass" on your menu? If not, start with one line on your next order.

Q2 THE NON-DRINKING GUEST

Do you offer non-alcoholic beer or a zero-proof highball? 92% of NA buyers still buy alcohol too (NielsenIQ, U.S.), and Korea points the same way — Instagram NA mentions jumped 41% in a month. This menu doesn't stop selling drinks; it keeps guests at the table.

Q3 THE ONE THING WORTH A PHOTO

Glassware, serve or staging — is there one element that begs a photo? 42% of young guests act on promotions they saw online. One scene in your bar is your advertising.

Two or more "no"s means your menu's center of gravity still sits with volume drinks. Talk to your Sewang sales rep for a distilled-soju, whisky and NA lineup sized to your bar.

Autumn's First Signal Comes After the Rain

Last issue we wrote that this year's "Cheoseo magic" failed to fire — and the heat held for more than a week after. The turn came on the last weekend of August: heavy rain nationwide brought Seoul's daytime highs down to around 28°C.

As of publication morning, the forecast still calls for late-summer highs near 30°C this week — but morning lows have dropped to 19–21°C, and the daily swing has opened wide. Autumn arrives in the mornings and evenings before it reaches midday. Keep the summer lineup (highballs, draft beer), but switch on the three signals: are whisky-on-the-rocks orders rising, is outdoor seating fading, are warm dishes moving first?

Social mentions of sake have moved sideways all summer — no reason to rush. The moment one signal turns "yes" is the moment to start ordering sake and warm dishes. We check the first September weekend's readings next issue.

NEXT ISSUE

The Chuseok D-15 final check — a reminder of the holiday ordering deadlines, plus measured results on the autumn switch from September's first weekend.

A Partner That Grows With You

From holiday pre-orders to the post-holiday dinner season, your Sewang sales rep plans around your bar's situation. Founded in 1978 — nearly half a century of full-line liquor wholesale across Seoul and Gyeonggi.

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